

BUBBLE TEA NEWS

Issue 21 · 4 December 2026 · Complimentary — please take one

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BREAKING · PURIRI LANE

Someone's Been Leaving Perfectly Ripe Lemons In A Basket At The Bus Stop, Take-One Sign Included

Case definition: a small woven basket, appearing most mornings at the Puriri Lane bus stop, containing between six and ten lemons and a handwritten "take one" sign in the same handwriting each time. Eleven mornings running as of Tuesday. Nobody has claimed responsibility. Nobody has taken more than one lemon, either, which the street finds almost more remarkable than the basket itself.

Community Outbreak Bulletin

BUSINESS · MARKETS

The Year-End Number, Arriving Two Weeks Early

Sherman McCoy

The year-end number came in two weeks ahead of schedule this time, which Judy took as a sign I'd finally relaxed and I took as a sign the market had simply run out of patience before I did. Marshall didn't stir from the door. I told him it was early. He didn't care. Neither, really, did I, once I'd actually seen it.

THE SILENT MAJORITY REPORT

On The Subject Of The Recycling Audit

Richard Nixon

The council now sends a representative to inspect recycling bins for correct sorting, unannounced, without appointment. I recognize this instrument precisely. Surveillance dressed as civic virtue is still surveillance, and I say that as a man who once found himself on the wrong side of exactly this kind of unannounced inspection, though the stakes, admittedly, were somewhat different.



TECHNOLOGY · REALITY DISTORTION FIELD

The Lid That Remembers Your Name

This week, a bubble tea shop three blocks from here started printing the customer's name directly onto the cup lid instead of a sticker. That is the plain fact. Everything about how you receive a drink just changed forever. For decades, humanity has been trapped by stickers that peel wrong. Today, that ends. This isn't a lid. It's a statement about what's possible when you stop asking permission to be permanent. Insanely great.

Steve Jobs

WEATHER · EPIC FORECAST

A Genuine December Warm-Up, Finally Behaving Like The Calendar Says It Should

Dana Foley

Twenty-four degrees by Thursday, the first number this month that actually matches what the calendar's been promising since the first. I've been burned enough times this season to hedge, so: enjoy it while it holds, and don't put the umbrella too far out of reach just yet.

BUBBLE TEA TRIVIA · DID YOU KNOW?

Wintermelon Tea Isn't Actually A Winter Melon

Despite the name, wintermelon tea isn't made from a "winter" melon at all. It's a variety of gourd, also called ash gourd, that's actually harvested in the warmer months.



In Every Issue

A new logic puzzle

Fresh local trivia

A rotating cast of columnists

Local ad space, weekly

Menace Watch, monthly — the editor's turn

"Surveillance dressed as civic virtue is still surveillance."

— Richard Nixon, The Silent Majority Report

JOKE OF THE WEEK

Why did the pearl take up gardening? It really wanted to grow on people.

STEEPED & SNUG
Loungewear built for a three-hour steep.
Comfort you can feel through the couch cushions.

PARODY PLACEMENT · INVENTED BRAND

PALMERS GARDEN ADDICTS

One more pot plant never hurt anyone.



Join the club. There's always room for one more.

PARODY PLACEMENT · NOT A REAL PALMERS AD



MARKETS · THE PEARL INDEX

The December Slowdown, Modelled Before It Happens

Fieldwork window: the two weeks leading into December across five counters, cross-referenced against the same window in each of the last two years I have data for. Method: comparing weekday foot traffic against the November average. Finding: a consistent 8 to 11% dip begins the first week of December every year I've checked (n=690 combined, ±3.2% MOE), presumably as everyone's attention shifts to actual holiday planning. Honest limitation: two years of comparison data is a pattern, not a law, but it's held both times I've had the chance to check it. I'll know for certain by the second week.

Priya Anand, *The Pearl Index*



PUZZLE OF THE WEEK

Which Size Did Dev Actually Buy?

Last issue's question, resolved: Grace didn't spot it at 4pm, and Iris spotted it exactly 4 hours after Moana. Only Moana = 12pm, Iris = 4pm clears both clues, leaving Grace at 8am. Grace spotted the trolley at 8am.

Three shoppers (Dev, Priya, Theo) each bought a different-sized potted plant this week from the garden centre: small, medium, large.

- Dev didn't buy the large.
- Theo's pot was one size up from Priya's.

Brisk one this week · which size did Dev actually buy? Answer next week — Ken Endo

BOOKS · THE DUCKWORTH SCALE

A Twist Ending That Actually Earns Its Reveal, For Once

Daffy Duck

I went in braced for disappointment, on account of every other twist this year landing with the grace of a piano off a roof. This one actually works, built fairly across three hundred pages instead of yanked out of nowhere in the last ten. Th-th-that's despicable. In the good way. I hate that there's a good way.

IN MEMORIAM

The Corner Table's Reserved Sign, Finally Removed

Skeletor

The corner table's permanently-reserved sign, held there for a regular who stopped coming in sometime around winter, was quietly removed this week and the table returned to general seating. I confess nothing about how long I personally kept that reservation standing past any reasonable justification. Mourn the sign if sentiment moves you toward laminated cardstock. I remain, as ever, unsentimental about seating charts, which is precisely why I noticed how long it took me to let this one go.

MUSIC

A Cover Version That Understands What Made The Original Work

Rebecca Black

Most covers either copy the original too closely or abandon everything that made it work in the first place. This one finds the actual middle: same emotional core, a genuinely different arrangement that earns its own reason to exist. I've had my own work covered badly enough times to recognize when someone's actually listened first. This one listened.

SPORT · READING THE WATER

A Substitution Read Ten Minutes Before It Happened

T. Marlow

Their striker's first touch had gone heavy twice in five minutes, a tell I've clocked in a hundred tiring legs before this one. Called the substitution to the row behind me with ten minutes still on the clock. Coach took eleven. I'll take the ten. Nobody in the stand believed me until the number went up.

DOMESTIC DESK

The Gutter Cleared Before The First Real Rain

Sebastian

The gutters came clear this year two days ahead of the season's first proper downpour, no last-minute scramble up the ladder in the wrong weather, no overflow down the side wall Sebastian has patched more times than he can accurately recall. He stood at the base of the ladder afterward longer than putting it away required. Some years the timing works out. He has learned not to expect it, which is, he supposes, the only way it keeps managing to surprise him.

ASK THE CAPTAIN

How Do I Stop Overcommitting Every December?

Horatio McCallister

"Every December I say yes to everything and burn out by New Year's. How do I stop?" Ye can't chart a course by every light on the shore, lad, only the ones worth the detour. Pick your ports before the season starts, not after ye're already three harbours deep and exhausted. Fair winds.

CLASSIFIEDS · TE MANA WHAKAATU FORMAT

FOR SALE: One Slightly Overgrown Garden, Tools Included

FOR SALE: entire back garden, slightly overgrown, tools included (one spade, one pair of shears, one hose with a mysterious permanent kink). Vendor cites "a genuinely heated dispute with the neighbour over the hedge line" as reason for sale. **Rated M.** Contains coarse language (directed at the hedge), mild peril (the shears have a loose rivet), and unresolved tension regarding whether the kink in the hose predates the current owner.

Satire · not affiliated with the real Classification Office of New Zealand.

THE BOBA SIDE

Not rendered artwork — delivered as a structured single-panel description (no renderer available this session):

Sub-style anchor: shoujo magical-girl beat, played dead straight. **Scene:** a barista, backlit, one hand raised, sparkle effect radiating outward, speed lines behind her, staring down the very last pearl clinging to the inside wall of an otherwise empty jar. **Caption:** "It ends when I say it ends."

The Boba Side — original pen-and-paper gag; art to follow in a future issue.